

Title: Beyond the Workshop: Sustained Impact of CPSP Examiner Training on Assessment Practice — A Mixed-Methods Study

Background

The College of Physicians & Surgeons Pakistan (CPSP), Pakistan's premier specialist education regulatory body, continually endeavours to enhance the quality and standardization of its 90 structured Fellowship programs, including its assessment systems. Recognizing the critical role of examiners, the Directorate of Medical Education with expert consensus developed and launched a structured Examiner Training Workshop in 2023. To date, 21 workshops have trained approximately 1,000 examiners nationwide. Given the limited evidence on long-term outcomes of such training, this study explored sustained changes in assessment practices and contextual challenges affecting implementation in a resource-limited setting. (93)

Summary of Work

A sequential mixed-methods design was employed. In phase 1, approximately 1,000 examiners completed a standardized multiple-choice pre- and post-test immediately before and after CPSP training to quantify short-term learning gains. In phase 2, 61 examiners from various specialties completed a structured follow-up questionnaire 12–18 months post-training, assessing the frequency of preferred examiner behaviors, use of consensus keys, utilisation of workplace-based assessment (WPBA) techniques, and use of post-item analysis feedback. Open-ended responses were thematically analyzed to identify barriers and enablers to sustained practice. (83)

Summary of Results

Training resulted in an approximately 70% increase in test scores immediately post-workshop. In the follow-up survey, 86% of respondents reported regular use of preferred examiner behaviors, 75% consistently used consensus keys, and 90% reported applying WPBA techniques in practice. However, only 43% consistently utilised post-item analysis feedback. Examiners from Medicine and Allied specialties showed slightly higher compliance than those from Surgery and Allied disciplines, who cited heavier workloads and structural constraints as key barriers. Qualitative themes included time pressures, limited institutional support, and variable examiner collaboration. Suggested reinforcements included refresher training, mentorship, and improved examiner orientation. (96)

Discussion and Conclusion

CPSP's examiner training demonstrates sustained behavioral change beyond initial knowledge gains. However, contextual barriers such as heavy workloads, limited organizational support, and variable examiner collaboration hinder translation into routine practice. To maximise impact, ongoing reinforcement through refresher modules and mentoring, along with institutional measures such as protected time and strengthened collaboration, are recommended. These findings may inform similar initiatives in postgraduate health professions education. (64)

Take-Home Message

While examiner training improves assessment practices, enduring impact requires structured reinforcement and systems-level support. (14)